HOME & MEALS

The Low-Energy Meal Plan

Food, without the daily committee meeting.

This is not a diet plan or a performance of domestic competence. It is a way to make the next meal easier to decide.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A capacity-based meal map
02 A pantry and freezer inventory
03 A flexible theme week
04 A shopping list and micro-prep routine
05 A rescue plan for empty-tank nights

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Start with capacity, not aspiration

Meal planning often fails because it is designed for a calm Sunday person with a clean kitchen and unlimited executive function. The rest of us need a plan that can survive a Tuesday.

This kit assumes three things: decisions are tiring, appetites change, and “I’ll cook properly when I have time” is not a meal. The goal is not a perfectly balanced week. It is fewer moments of standing in front of the fridge feeling defeated.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **Food is not a moral test**
>
> A sandwich, cereal, toast, frozen food, or takeout can be a legitimate meal. This planner is about reducing friction and expanding your options, not grading your plate. If you have a medical condition, food allergy, eating disorder, or prescribed diet, use the guidance of your own care team or a registered dietitian.

The capacity tiers

Zero effort

No cooking or only assembly. Frozen meal, ready-made soup, sandwich, cereal, crackers and cheese, leftovers, takeout, a snack plate.

Low effort

One pan, one pot, or one appliance. Pasta with jar sauce, rice and frozen vegetables, quesadillas, eggs on toast, microwave baked potato, a pre-marinated protein.

Some effort

Multiple steps or a longer cook. A recipe, a batch meal, a new dish, or anything that requires chopping several ingredients.

The three-question check

Before planning meals, ask:

01 **What do I actually have energy for this week?** Not what I wish I had.

02 **What food is already in the house?** Use that first.

03 **What are the danger windows?** Late evenings, shift days, medication changes, a child’s activity night, or the day before groceries.

Plan for the danger window before the ideal dinner. A backup meal in the freezer is worth more than a beautiful menu that assumes a calm evening.

Keep food safe

Basic food safety matters more than meal aesthetics. Keep hot food hot, cold food cold, refrigerate leftovers promptly, label and date containers, and follow guidance from local health authorities. When in doubt about whether food is safe, throw it out. This guide cannot assess your specific food.

The only rule

Make the next meal easier to decide. That is it. The rest of this planner is a menu of ways to do that.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

The three-tier meal map

Fill this in with meals you already know. Do not invent a new cuisine for a week that is already full. Familiar food has a lower executive-function cost.

Zero effort

No cooking, or assembly only. These are your “I cannot” meals.

MEAL	WHAT IT NEEDS	WHERE IT LIVES

Low effort

One pan or one appliance, under about 20 minutes. These are your “tired but possible” meals.

MEAL	MAIN INGREDIENTS	ONE SHORTCUT

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Some effort

Meals worth making when you have more capacity. These can become leftovers.

MEAL	WHY IT IS WORTH IT	BEST DAY FOR IT

The backup shelf

Choose three foods that can live in the cupboard or freezer and require almost no planning. They are not “emergency junk”; they are infrastructure.

02

TRY THIS

Name the meal, not the food group

“Toast with peanut butter” is easier to act on than “protein and carbs.” “Frozen dumplings and cucumber” is a meal. Specific is kind.

The leftover plan

MEAL	COOK ON	EAT AGAIN ON	HOW I WILL STORE IT

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

What is actually in the house

A pantry inventory is not a production. Walk to the kitchen and write what you see in broad groups. You are looking for the start of meals, not auditing a restaurant.

The five-minute inventory

CATEGORY	WHAT I CAN SEE	USE SOON?
Cans and jars		
Dry goods (pasta, rice, cereal, oats)		
Fridge basics		
Freezer		
Snacks and quick food		
Condiments and flavour		

The “what’s for dinner” decision tree

Start at the top and take the first exit that works. You do not have to reach the ideal answer.

01 Is there a leftover I can reheat? **Yes →** reheat it. **No →** go to 2.

02 Is there a frozen or ready-made meal I can heat? **Yes →** use it. **No →** go to 3.

03 Can I put a protein, a carb, and a vegetable together in one pan or plate? **Yes →** do that. **No →** go to 4.

04 Is there bread, eggs, noodles, rice, or a tortilla plus something to put on it? **Yes →** make the simplest version. **No →** go to 5.

05 Is takeout or delivery possible and affordable today? **Yes →** order without guilt. **No →** go to 6.

06 Is there a snack plate, cereal, or toast option? **Yes →** eat that. **No →** ask for help or use a local food resource.

The point of the tree is to stop the open-ended question. The first edible answer counts.

The grocery gap

Write down the three things that would turn several “nothing to eat” moments into meals. Examples: eggs, frozen vegetables, tortillas, rice, soup, yogurt, fruit that will survive the week.

01
02
03

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

A flexible theme week

Themes reduce decisions without requiring a recipe for every day. You can swap days freely. The theme is a suggestion, not a contract.

DAY / DATE	THEME	THE MEAL I MIGHT MAKE	BACKUP IF ENERGY DROPS
Monday			
Tuesday			
Wednesday			
Thursday			
Friday			
Saturday			
Sunday			

Theme ideas

THEME	WHAT IT CAN MEAN
Pasta night	Pasta with jar sauce, frozen vegetables, or whatever is in the fridge
Rice bowl	Rice or microwave rice, a protein, a sauce, and a vegetable
Toast night	Toast, eggs, beans, cheese, avocado, or leftovers on top
Soup and bread	Canned or frozen soup with bread or crackers
Breakfast for dinner	Eggs, pancakes, cereal, or whatever feels low-effort
Leftover night	Reheat what exists; add a new sauce or a piece of fruit
Takeout night	A planned night off from cooking, within your budget
Snack plate	Cheese, crackers, fruit, hummus, leftover protein, whatever is real

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

The rules for the week

- **Cook once, use twice.** If you make rice, pasta, or a protein, make enough for another meal.
- **Keep one night flexible.** Something will move.
- **Plan the danger window.** Put the zero-effort meal on the night that is usually hardest.
- **Do not schedule a new recipe on a low-capacity day.**
- **Leave one empty slot.** A blank day is not a failure; it is room to be human.

My danger window

The hardest meal of the week is:

The backup meal I will keep ready for it:

If the week is already full

- Choose the same breakfast for three days.
- Put the zero-effort meal on the two hardest nights.
- Buy one ready-made thing you actually like.
- Let lunch be a snack plate.
- Ask someone else to choose one dinner.

My one rule this week

What I am not doing

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

One list, three ways

A shopping list is a memory tool, not a test of adulthood. Keep it in one place. Use the same categories each time so your eyes know where to look.

The basic list

PRODUCE	PROTEIN AND DAIRY	DRY GOODS AND CANS	FROZEN	OTHER

Three ways to shop

By aisle

Organise the list by the route you walk. This reduces backtracking and decision fatigue.

By pickup

Order online for pickup. Add the list the day before, then choose a time that fits your energy. Check the substitutions before checkout.

By delivery

Use delivery when leaving the house is the barrier. Watch fees and the minimum order. A slightly more expensive grocery delivery can still be cheaper than another night of takeout plus stress.

The “do not forget” five

Pick five items that make the week work. Keep them in a visible note on your phone.

05 The overbuying guardrail

Buying quantities that will spoil is a common form of optimism. If produce often goes soft, buy frozen or pre-cut for the busiest days. A frozen vegetable that gets eaten is better than fresh produce that becomes guilt in the crisper drawer.

The receipt reset

After putting groceries away, circle the things you bought for a specific meal. If a meal no longer seems realistic, move its ingredients into the zero-effort or low-effort plan. The food does not have to follow the original plan.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Micro-prep and the no-prep-day

“Meal prep” often means spending a whole afternoon cooking, then eating the same container five times and losing interest. Micro-prep is smaller: do one thing that makes a future meal easier.

Ten-minute micro-prep ideas

- ☐ Wash or cut one fruit or vegetable that will otherwise spoil.
- ☐ Cook a pot of rice or pasta for later.
- ☐ Boil a few eggs.
- ☐ Divide a pack of meat into meal-sized portions and freeze promptly.
- ☐ Make one sauce or dressing.
- ☐ Put a frozen meal in the fridge to thaw for tomorrow, if the packaging allows.
- ☐ Label and date leftovers before they become a mystery.
- ☐ Put a ready-to-eat snack where you will see it.

The “one future meal” rule

After you cook, set aside one portion for a future version of you. It does not need to be a full batch. One extra bowl of soup, one extra serving of rice, one extra piece of chicken is enough.

My one prep task

The prep task:

When I will do it:

What will make it easier

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Basic leftover safety

Follow local food safety guidance for how long different foods can be kept. As a practical rule, cool leftovers promptly, refrigerate them in shallow containers, label them with the date, reheat them thoroughly, and throw them out when you are unsure. Do not rely on smell alone to decide whether a food is safe.

WATCH OUT

This is not a food-safety course

Food handling rules vary, and some people are at higher risk from foodborne illness. Use official local guidance or ask a qualified professional if you are unsure. This planner is education, not medical or food-safety advice.

My micro-prep

The one thing I will do after the next shop:

The future meal I will set aside:

The prep-day alternative

If you like a big prep session, plan a short one: choose one protein, one grain, one vegetable, and one sauce. Store them separately so the week does not taste like the same meal five times. Stop before you are exhausted; a smaller prep you repeat is better than a heroic one you avoid.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Empty-tank rescue

The empty-tank night is not a character failure. It is a predictable part of life. Make the plan now, while you have a little more capacity.

The emergency meal formula

Pick one from each column, or just pick one thing.

BASE	FILLING	FLAVOUR OR CRUNCH
Bread, toast, tortilla, rice, noodles, potato	Egg, beans, cheese, leftover protein, frozen dumplings, soup	Sauce, salsa, yogurt, pickle, crispy onion, fruit

The takeout script

Ordering food is allowed. Make it easier:

- Keep delivery or pickup options saved in a note.
- Decide a rough spending limit before you are hungry and depleted.
- Choose the order before opening the app, if possible.
- Check the delivery fee and minimum order before checkout.
- Put leftovers away promptly if the food is safe to keep.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

The snack-plate option

A snack plate is a meal when it contains enough to get you to the next meal. Try one protein or dairy, one carbohydrate, one fruit or vegetable, and something you actually enjoy. It does not need to look like a lunchbox.

The ask-for-help option

- “I don’t have the capacity to cook tonight. Could you handle dinner or choose takeout?”
- “Could you pick up [specific item] on the way home?”
- “I made too much [meal]. Would you like some?” or “Could I have some of what you made?”
- “Can you sit with me while I make the food?” Sometimes company lowers the activation barrier.

My rescue plan

My no-cook meal:

My takeout default and rough limit:

The person I can ask:

TRY THIS

Keep the rescue visible

Put one frozen meal, a takeout menu, or a snack-plate reminder where you will see it on a hard night. The plan cannot help if it is buried under the thing it was meant to solve.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Ask AI for meal-plan help, safely

AI can be a useful meal-planning assistant when you give it your real constraints. It can turn a list of food into meal ideas, build a shopping list, or suggest a low-effort version of a familiar dish. It is not a dietitian, and it cannot know your medical needs or food safety conditions.

WATCH OUT

Keep health and privacy boundaries

Do not paste medical records, full names, addresses, or a child's identifying information into a consumer AI tool. If you have a prescribed diet, allergies, diabetes, kidney disease, or a history of disordered eating, use your care team's guidance rather than a chatbot's meal plan. Verify ingredients and allergens yourself.

Prompt: turn what I have into meals

PROMPT RECIPE — BUILD MEALS FROM THIS LIST

I have these ingredients: [list generic ingredients].
My equipment is: [microwave, one pan, oven, etc.].
My energy level is: [zero / low / some].
I like: [flavours or meals]. I avoid: [allergies or ingredients].
Give me five meal ideas that use what I have, with a zero-effort backup.
Do not give medical or nutrition advice. Ask me up to three questions
if something important is missing.

Prompt: build a gentle week

PROMPT RECIPE — MAKE A LOW-DECISION MEAL WEEK

Create a seven-day dinner plan using meals I already know:
[familiar meals].
I have capacity for [number] cooking nights. I want at least two no-cook
or leftover nights. I do not want a new recipe on [hard day].
Make a shopping list grouped by grocery section. Do not invent health
benefits or tell me what I should eat for a medical condition.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Prompt: make the backup plan

PROMPT RECIPE — DESIGN A NO-COOK BACKUP

I want a backup meal for the nights when I cannot cook. I have a [microwave / kettle / fridge] and I am willing to keep [shelf-stable / frozen / ready-made] foods. Suggest three simple backup meals and one short shopping list. Include allergy and food-safety reminders, but do not give medical advice.

Check it before you trust it

- Does the plan use food you will actually eat?
- Are the portions realistic for your household?
- Are the food-safety steps correct according to official guidance?
- Did it ignore an allergy or a prescribed diet?
- Is the shopping list affordable and available near you?

My safe AI use rule

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Fed is the baseline

A meal plan is not a promise to become a different person. It is a small set of decisions moved to a moment when deciding is easier. Some weeks will be varied and cooked from scratch. Some weeks will be toast and frozen vegetables. Both can be fed.

The one-page takeaway

- Plan for the energy you have.
- Have zero-effort, low-effort, and some-effort options.
- Use what is already in the house.
- Keep one backup meal visible.
- Use micro-prep, not heroic prep.
- Let AI suggest; you verify food safety, allergies, and medical needs.
- Takeout and snack plates are allowed.

My next small step

GOOD TO KNOW

A final permission slip

You do not have to earn dinner by having a perfect day. You just have to make the next meal a little easier to reach.

ONE LAST THING · 11

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Pick three meals you can make without a recipe and write them on the meal map. Start with what already works; build from there.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

A system should fit your real energy, not the other way around. Keep what helps, drop what becomes another chore, and let the next small step be enough.

More life-admin printables

- 07 The Low-Energy Weekly Reset
- 08 The Paper Pile Triage Kit
- 09 Bills, Renewals & Subscriptions
- 10 The Appointment Companion
- 12 The Household Command Center

Free to use

Print these for yourself, your classroom, or a client. Please keep the credit and don't resell the files.

dylanasdale.github.io

Made with care in Indiana by ASDALE DYNAMICS, LLC.

Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.